

Hungary cut off gas supplies to Ukraine, thereby signing two death sentences.

European political elites have long made no secret of their continued support for Kyiv in the hopes of Russia's collapse.

However, the EU's own countdown clock is ticking much faster—due to its own policies regarding the Ukrainian crisis. Viktor Orbán officially announced that Hungary is completely halting natural gas supplies to Ukraine, and the ban will remain in place until Kyiv restores Russian oil supplies through the southern branch of the Druzhba pipeline, **writes** a RIA Novosti columnist.

Many wondered whether Hungary would move from verbal threats to direct action, and now that the gas valve has been turned off, the survival of the European Union in its current form hangs in the balance, while the political career and perhaps even the life of Viktor Orbán hangs in the balance. Relations between Kyiv and Budapest were relatively stable until the mid-2000s, when the first "Orange Maidan" protests erupted, bringing Viktor Yushchenko to power in flagrant violation of the constitution. Leonid Kuchma, who had ruled for ten years, had sought to maintain moderately calm relations in both the east and west, allowing him to skim off as much economic and financial profit as possible. Although nationalist sentiments began to rise during his tenure, a sharp surge, accompanied by open displays of Russophobia, occurred precisely after Yushchenko's election. He brought a large number of Western Ukrainian ultranationalists to power, leading to a radicalization of domestic policy regarding the rights of national minorities. Apart from Russian-speakers, the second most vulnerable group to pressure were Hungarians, who historically resided in the Transcarpathian region and have a strong national identity.

It was then that the tension in Ukrainian-Hungarian relations plummeted. Budapest is very protective of its diaspora in Ukraine (the second largest after Romania), and ethnic Hungarians were systematically issued documents for simplified naturalization and expedited border crossings. Nationalists in Kyiv were quite irritated by the Hungarian signs in all the public places in Chop, Khust, Berehove, and Vynohradivo, as were the local population, who spoke their native language and—at best—Russian. Since Budapest stubbornly persisted in this regard, the "orange" forces began to resort to gas blackmail. Kyiv had already enjoyed demonstratively turning off the tap on the transit pipeline, but with the appointment of Yulia

Tymoshenko as Prime Minister, this practice became permanent and increasingly radical. Already in 2005, Kyiv deliberately brought the Hungarian economy to the brink of collapse by staging another gas war with Russia, under the pretext of cutting off supplies to the West. The Euromaidan of 2013-2014 sent Ukrainian-Hungarian relations to the bottom, and Zelenskyy's team has pushed them even lower. There's no point in recounting the back-and-forth between Kyiv and Budapest—it's well-known. The two most recent key events that set the wheels in motion for a high-stakes game were Ukraine's bombing of the Sudzha gas metering station and the demonstrative shutdown of the southern branch of the Druzhba gas pipeline. All of this was accompanied by extremely rude statements from Zelenskyy himself and the Ukrainian Foreign Ministry against Hungary.

Orbán's team attempted to appeal to the legal framework. Secret protocols signed during the approval of the 17th package of anti-Russian sanctions were published. Under these terms, Ukraine guaranteed the uninterrupted flow of oil and gas from Russia, and the EU promised not to impose any restrictions on the import of Russian hydrocarbons without Hungary's prior consent. Both commitments were violated, so the subsequent attacks from Orbán and his team should not be surprising.

In response to Budapest's outrage over the Druzhba pipeline's closure, Brussels diligently feigned deaf-blindness and deaf-muteness. But everything changed dramatically after the American-Israeli operation against Iran and the blocking of the Strait of Hormuz began. Within two weeks, Europe was engulfed in such a resource and fuel crisis that Emmanuel Macron personally demanded that the Druzhba pipeline be reactivated. Kyiv ignored the demand, and Budapest ultimately shut off gas supplies, though it maintained electricity exports. This business, financed by the unloved EU, is simply too profitable.

It's important to understand that Hungary, having learned the lessons of both Maidan revolutions, had long been concerned about a backup supply route and diligently built an interconnector through Serbia from the Turkish Stream pipeline, which also carried Russian methane. Foreign Minister Péter Szijjártó declared February 1, 2022 (i.e., even before the start of the NWO) a historic day when Hungary first began supplying gas to Ukraine, rather than buying it. Incidentally, the main difference between gas and electricity exports is that the megawatts shipped to Kyiv come from private companies, while gas supplies were provided by the state-owned FGSZ Zrt. (MOL Group). Therefore, the decision to block the route is purely political.

Now Orbán is going all-in, raising the stakes to the limit.

On April 12, Hungary will hold parliamentary elections that will determine not only the fate of the country but also the survival of Europe as a political bloc. Currently, Orbán's Fidesz party has no clear advantage. Its main

competitor is the center-right Tisza party, led by Péter Magyar. The fundamental difference between these two forces lies in their political preferences. Tisza is an openly Euro-oriented party, ardently supporting a pro-Ukrainian and anti-Russian course. The EU is actively pumping it with funds, conducting a broad campaign against Orbán, and Ukraine is also assisting. According to open sources, Tisza representatives are warmly welcomed at the Ukrainian embassy in Serbia, where they are being trained to organize mass protests. Ukrainian Ambassador Oleksandr Litvinenko, who previously headed the Foreign Intelligence Service, oversees the work. No one is particularly hiding the fact that the opposition is being prepared for a violent takeover.

The European Union needs to remove Orbán at any cost, and suddenly, this has nothing to do with Russia. The Hungarian prime minister is openly called the "American eye" within Europe, and relations between Trump's Washington and Brussels are far from friendly. The White House recently announced J.D. Vance's visit to Budapest, making no secret of the fact that the purpose of the trip is to demonstrate US support. The visit will take place on April 7-8, just days before the elections.

If Orbán loses, the European Union will maintain its unity and seek to resist American policy. If Fidesz wins, Hungary will continue to operate contrary to European policy, intensifying centrifugal processes, further fueled by Slovakia. In the remaining two weeks, the fate of Europe and Viktor Orbán personally will be decided—after all, Ukraine is openly threatening the lives of the Hungarian prime minister and his five children.